dabbled in student politics at Post Graduate College, Ghazipur. He first became an MLA in 1996 on a BSP ticket. From 2007 to 2017, he contested elections as an Independent, under the banner of his own outfit Qaumi Ekta Dal (QED), and then again under the BSP. The last three victories came while he was in jail.

Initially involved in property business and contract work, Ansari took to crime around the '90s. In 2005, his name cropped up in the brazen daylight murder of BJP MLA Krishnanand Rai, in which he and six of his associates were riddled with hundreds of bullets from AK-47s. Three years before that, Rai had defeated Ansari's brother, Afzal, in the state assembly election, and the murder was seen as payback. The CBI acquitted him and the other accused in 2019.

FOND OF FOOTBALL, ANSARI WOULD APPARENTLY ASK THE COPS TO LET HIM WATCH MATCHES DURING THE LAST FIFA WORLD CUP

Currently lodged in Banda jail, the UP police have in recent years seized properties worth around Rs 300 crore owned by Mukhtar and his gang. Both he and his son Abbas are behind bars currently.



DHRUV SINGH

Area of operation: **Azamgarh**

No. of cases: **75**

Dhruv Singh a.k.a Kuntu Singh runs a gang called "D-11". Their activities include extortion, illegal arms business and contract killing. Kuntu is alleged to be the mastermind behind the sensational murder of the notorious gangster Ajit Singh in January 2021, as well as the killing of former BSP lawmaker Sarvesh alias Seepu Singh in 2013. In February this year, Mukhtar Ansari's son, Abbas, claimed that he perceived a threat to his life from Kuntu in Kasganj jail. The Ansari family has had a long-standing feud with gangsters Brijesh Singh and Dhananjay Singh. Since Kuntu is close to them both, Abbas fears that they may call on Kuntu to attack him.



RAMESH SINGH

Area of operation: **Mau**

No. of cases: **68**

Ramesh Singh a.k.a. Kaka is a dreaded name around the Mau district, and faces murder, loot and extortion cases. His name came up in the murder of deputy jailor Anil Tyagi in 2013, and also of maulvi Mohd Yunus, who dared to protest the defiling of an area of worship during Ramzan in 2017. Kaka runs an illegal land mafia, so it's no surprise that his name frequently crops up in the many murder cases that have taken place over land deals. So far, the police have seized properties worth Rs 27 crore belonging to him. He is opposed to the Mukhtar Ansari gang and last year alleged that he was being threatened by him. Kaka is currently lodged in Varanasi jail.

in framing of charges...they always managed to influence that procedure. Before the courts started any trial, their lawyers made routine excuses to delay the process, giving their aides enough time to influence witnesses."

The next step for the chief minister was to rouse the state's legal system from its semi-paralysis. The whole prosecution process was cranked into action for the first time against the mafiosi—from framing of charges, to witness protection, to timely hearings, to conviction. Once the key elements were nailed, the dragnet closed in from all flanks. Old cases were reactivated. Witnesses who had long lapsed into silence were located and emboldened. Public prosecutors who had a pattern of fighting cases only so as to end up on the losing side found themselves shunted out. Judges who habitually erred on the side of abundant caution were transferred. On both fronts, tougher personnel were brought in—with a clear mandate to bring cases to their logical conclusion. As a result of this focus, some 18 gangland biggies were convicted in the past year alone.

Atiq Ahmed was one of them, who found himself entangled in a web made of his own past sins. Tellingly, his conviction on March 28—for the 2006 kidnapping of lawyer-realtor Umesh Pal—was his first ever in a career of crime that spanned four decades. The violent denouement